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On Syd Cohen, Harassed Umpires, and Other Such Things

By LOU PAVLOVICH

"MY BASEBALL AGE, you can say, is 40," Syd Cohen, the Arizona-Texas League's fiery (and comical) boss of the Bisbee-Douglas Copper Kings, was talking. It was an informal interview, with Syd munching on a giant hamburger at the time. Cohen's jaw was working hard on the burger, and he had a grizzled hand draped around a soft drink.

SYD DIDN'T GIVE his actual age, but those who have followed his career, ever since he broke into baseball in Arizona, went to the majors, and later became a manager in the southwest, swear that he is much closer to 50 years of age than 40.

"I'm ready to pitch again," the wily southpaw said, after washing down his hasty meal with a giant swig of pop. "But we'll see if they'll need me this year. . . . Sure I'll pitch if we are short-handed."



SYD COHEN

The conversation switched to an article that was done on Cohen by Associated Press scribe Gayle Talbott recently, and relayed over the national sports wire. Talbott's story compared Cohen with the colorful Rube Waddell and told how Buck Elliott, then managing Bisbee-Douglas, "robbed" Syd, who was El Paso's head man at the time, by delaying a night game at Douglas in the fifth inning until a rain storm washed out what should have been a Cohen victory.

Syd still remembered the incident. "That," he pointed a finger at us, "was a disgrace to baseball! Anytime a team can purposely delay a game and get away with it—why, the umpires aren't doing their job."

The story, in brief, told how Syd's team ran up a 9-0 lead after a couple of innings and Elliott's B-D team, noticing rain clouds forming, started to stall. By the time the last of the fifth came around, the air was damp with the prospect of rain. Syd was pitching and needed only three more outs to make it an official game. He was working fast as lightning.

B-D ADOPTED all the stalling tactics imaginable. Finally, with two out, the third B-D batter didn't get into the batting box quickly enough, and the umpire ordered Syd to pitch, anyway.

Syd tossed two in a hurry and the ump called them automatic strikes. On the third pitch, the batter jumped into the box and managed to get his bat on the ball and foul it off.

Right at that moment, the heaviest rain storm Arizona ever saw hit that ball park. A lightning bolt hit the transformer and every light in town went off, including those at the ball park. Everyone ran for the dressing room to keep from drowning in the darkness.

Elliott, after 30 minutes, noticed that the downpour let up a little and suddenly remembered that in the rush he had left the box containing his valuables on the bench. Elliott groped his way out into the ankle-high water, which went up to his knees when he stepped down into the dugout.

"I FOUND THE BOX," Elliott was quoted, "and was starting to wade back when I heard this slush-slush sound. I thought I was hearing things, because I knew nobody was out there, but I kept hearing it, and pretty soon I saw this figure coming out of the gloom. It was Syd, and he passed within three feet without seeing me."

"He had been standing out there on that mound for 30 minutes, waiting to make that last pitch. I heard later that he was so wet that the tobacco in his upper pocket had dissolved and trickled all over him."

AS FUNNY as the story is, Syd still is perturbed over the delaying action on that night, some four

years ago. "I remember when I used to pitch for Chattanooga; we had a manager who made us stall like that, too," Syd declared.

"One game, in which I happened to be pitching, we got orders to stall. The catcher tossed the ball back way over my head. The centerfielder retrieved the ball and made a bad throw to the shortstop. The shortstop threw way wide to me. When I finally got the ball, I had to tie my shoe strings. And so it went."

"WE THOUGHT we got away with it until the next day—when we heard that our manager was fined \$100 . . . and the club \$250."

THE CONVERSATION got around to Ray Cady, a stormy petrel on the A-T league umpiring staff, if there ever was one. The night a few years back that Ump Cady was almost "stoned" to death by irate Tucson baseball fans here was recalled.

And Cohen had a story to tell about Cady.

"When I managed El Paso," the lefthander started, "we needed one more win to get into the playoffs. We were playing Phoenix that night. And, strangely, I happened to be pitching. Well, there was a play at first base and Cady called a Phoenix runner safe when he should have been out. I told my bullpen pitcher to start warming up—cause I knew darn well that I wasn't going to stay in that ball game long. Well, Phoenix got a nine-run lead on us and our play-off chances looked bad."

"A little later I got into a helluva ruckus with Cady on another play. I told him plenty and finally he ordered me out of the game. I told him to put me out, himself, if he thought he could do it. So he says to me, 'I can get you out of here,' and he motions to a couple of policemen in the stands."

"The policemen started walking slowly toward me—I knew them real well, actually—so I said to myself, 'Syd, you can walk out of here by yourself, without any help,' so I started to leave."

THE POLICEMEN, watching me leave, turned back and went into the stands. But out of the corner of my eye I saw them and as soon as they left, I stormed back at Cady and kept up the ruckus."

"After a few minutes, Cady was screaming for the police again, but when they started toward me for the second time I left real suddenly—for good. "But, would you believe it, my boys scored nine runs that inning and we beat Phoenix to get into the playoffs!"

ODDS AND ENDS—Coach John Richards of Benson high has a good story to tell on his fabulous Eddie Lee. It seems that the evening Lee scored 28½ points against Bisbee high in last week's track and field meet at Benson. Eddie pulled a fast one on his coach.

"I was busy down at one end of the track," Richards explains, "and I looked up just as the high hurdles event was ready to start. And there was Eddie, lined up and ready to go. He sneaked in as a Benson entry—I have never used him in the high hurdles because he has too many events as it is—and dangled if he didn't win it."

"He went on to score 28½ points. You know, I just couldn't get mad at that little rascal . . . he is such a nice, modest kid. But I sure hope I don't get any criticism for overworking him."

WRESTLER GORGEOUS GEORGE returns to the Sports Center Wednesday. The Gorgeous one, you will recall, has a turkey ranch at Beaumont, Calif. Here's

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